



MILITARY CHAPLAINCY AT A GLANCE

1. Speaking at a Jewish cemetery Memorial Day service, Seattle, Washington | Photo credit: Meryl Alcabes Photography
2. Tefillin at an air show at Joint Base Lewis-McChord, Washington
3. Illuminating Patrick Air Force Base | Photo credit: Chavi Konikov
4. Rabbi Estrin (second from right) takes his place in the annual Kinus Hashluchim photo together with fellow shluchim who serve as chaplains in the US Military | Photo credit: Itzik Roytman

SERVICE TYPE	✈️ ACTIVE DUTY	🏠 RESERVE DUTY	🏠 IMA (Individual Mobilization Augmentee) RESERVES
PREREQUISITES	• Below age 46 • In good physical health • Bachelor's and Master's equivalent (semicha certificate) • Ability to work well with others of all faiths		
AMOUNT OF TIME SPENT ON BASE	Chaplain lives on base and will be transferred to a new base every 2-3 years	Chaplain visits base one weekend per month and two weeks per summer	Chaplain spends 24 days of his choice per year on base
DEPLOYMENT	Yes	Deployment possible for six months per two years if unit is called at that time	Not required
TRAINING REQUIREMENTS	INITIAL: 14 weeks on training base (eight weeks officer training, six weeks chaplaincy course) ONGOING: Occasional courses for development, in accordance with rank		
MONETARY BENEFITS	Compensation for days spent on base; family health insurance; occasional bonuses		
IDEAL FOR	Shliach who is ready to make military chaplaincy his family's full-time shlichus	Shliach living near army base who wishes to make military chaplaincy a large part of his shlichus	Shliach to community or campus of less than 2,000 Jews

PRISON CHAPLAINCY

Fit For a Prince

At a farbrengen on motzoei Shabbos kodesh Parshas Vayakhel 5738, the Rebbe posed the following question: “If Hashem wants a Jew to be in prison, who are we to mix in and make him or her happy?” The Rebbe then answered, “Every Jew is a child of the King of Kings. If a prince would find himself in a *makom bilti ratzui*, we would do everything in our power to give him what he needs. Likewise, every Jew—even a Jew in prison—should have everything he needs and in a manner that befits a prince.”

This is the ethos that spurs many shluchim to take the time to reach out and care for Jews held in prisons in or near their makom hashlichus. Some do it voluntarily while others are officially retained as chaplains by the prisons. In addition, Aleph Institute sends out hundreds of bachurim each year to visit Jews in prisons in towns and cities across the United States.

“We are charged with the mission of creating a *dirah* for Hashem, *davka betachtonim*,” states Rabi Binyomin Scheiman, shliach in Des Plaines, Illinois. “When you visit a Jew who finds himself in a place of immense darkness and you put on tefillin with him, you are making a *dirah* in a *tachton she’ein tachton lematzah mimenah*, which is Hashem’s ultimate desire.” Rabbi Scheiman has such a strong belief in the importance of this shlichus that he has even brought out two shluchim to help him.

A GROWING SHLICHUS

Rabbi Scheiman was first brought to Chicago to run the Gan Yisrael day camp and help out with mitzvot in 5740. The head shliach at the time, Rabbi Daniel Moskowitz AH, jokingly

asked him to limit his peulos to projects that wouldn’t add expense to an already tight budget. Ever enterprising, Rabbi Scheiman began to visit nearby penitentiaries, searching for Jews who were holed up and lost to general society. “The first people I visited were so thankful. I saw how meaningful my visits were to them that I made a *hachlatah* to see to it that any Jew incarcerated in Illinois would receive a visit at least once a month,” he says.

Though Rabbi Scheiman initially encountered resistance from authorities who didn’t want to grant him—an unrecognized clergyman—access to the names of Jewish inmates, he involved Jewish politicians who argued that if priests and imams could be granted such information, so could a rabbi. Once he had access to the names, he began to visit as a volunteer, driving hundreds of miles from prison to prison. Rabbi Scheiman made contacts and developed relationships with prison officials and, after a while, was contracted as the official prison chaplain at a number of facilities. As he spent more and more time on the road, sometimes making five-day circular trips to the prisons, the *hachlatah* he had made in those early days became his entire shlichus. Six years ago, in memory of his first wife, Mrs. Hinda Scheiman AH, he expanded his team. With three shluchim and twenty volunteers, they now visit Jews in up to thirty prisons each month.

Rabbi Zalman Fischer, shliach in Augusta, Georgia, found himself with some extra time in the early days of his shlichus. He offered his services as a rabbi to the local prisons and began visiting the Jews who were there. In time, the facilities saw the benefit of having a Jewish chaplain available to respond to the specific needs of their Jewish population and Rabbi Fischer was offered a contract. Rabbi Fischer, though, still balances his chaplaincy with a community shlichus that has baruch Hashem grown in the last twenty years.

“Nowadays, my shlichus is full-on and demands all my time,” he says, “but I know that I am the only Jew some of these people will see. How can I deny them this already minimal access?” Rabbi Fischer sets aside one afternoon a month per prison, giving him time to travel, visit, and return, and the ability to focus on his other duties the rest of the time.

KNOW BEFORE YOU GO



On arrest, a person will be held at a county jail or police station until he is either released or arraigned.

Those who are not released from county jails are sent to state or federal prison. In order to be allowed to visit or even to be granted access to the personal information of any person brought to a police station or county jail, a shliach will need to contact his local law enforcement agency. Permission to visit someone in a state prison will require the shliach to undergo a background check as well. The prerequisites for visitations to federal prisons, however, are more rigorous, mandating yearly drug tests and background checks every five years, as well as an escort by prison guards during each visit. Regardless of the institution, the person will need to have requested a visit from a rabbi in order for the shliach to be permitted to see him.

As a chaplain, Rabbi Scheiman is provided with access to the personal information of any person who is being held at the local Cook County Jail. “Most of the people being held at county jails or police stations end up being released or transferred within a week so it’s important for us to stay in the know,” he says. “At this level, it is easier for us to access the people and provide support to them and their families.” With the information he receives, Rabbi Scheiman is able to contact the family



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5. Rabbi Zalman Fischer
6. Rabbi Binyomin Scheiman

PAYING IT FORWARD

While making his rounds at a Chicago prison, Rabbi Scheiman met Jeremy, an 18-year-old Jew from Chicago's rough South Side. Rabbi Scheiman visited him regularly until his release 10 years ago at the age of 36.

After his release, Jeremy was hired at a real estate firm and worked hard to make a life for himself. Though he lived 180 miles away, Rabbi Scheiman made the effort to visit him on a monthly basis. "I'd bring corned beef sandwiches, we'd chat, and put on tefillin," he says. "We still do."

Having recently been promoted to the position of partner in his firm, Jeremy now gives Rabbi Scheiman a significant donation annually in appreciation for the visits that meant so much to him. "When I was incarcerated, I promised that when I would be released and start to earn money I would give ten percent of my earnings to Rabbi Scheiman so that others could receive that which was given to me," he had said.

members of those who self-identify as Jews and verify their Jewishness before making his first visit. Rabbi Scheiman adds, though, that it is not standard protocol for a chaplain to be granted access to this information. "The more a shliach develops and cultivates a positive relationship with the officials, the more likely they are to help him and give him the information he needs."

Rabbi Fischer points out that many non-Jews "convert" to Judaism while in prison. While these people are not our target audience, the fact that they request Jewish services increases the "Jewish" presence in the facility and the need for Jewish resources to be provided to the chaplain.

Rabbi Scheiman's son Rabbi Chaim Scheiman now visits Cook County

Jail every week to be there for any Jew who has been arrested. Not only does this enable him to serve as a source of support to a person who stands at the beginning of a sentence, but it also serves as a gateway through which to establish connection with a person who might be released in a matter of days but will still need to navigate through the aftermath of his arrest while back at home.

State and federal prisons throughout the country vary in their levels of security and each have their own visitation restrictions. "You have to base what you do on the type of facility and, more importantly, on the crowd," Rabbi Fischer says. "Sometimes we'll daven or learn something. Other times we'll just schmooze. These are people who feel they have lost everything, including the

respect of those they hold dearest. I try to give them a little feeling of hope and encourage them to believe that they can better themselves.”

MAGNIFYING THE POINT OF CONTACT

In 5743 Rabbi Scheiman was contacted by a Jewish woman whose 16-year-old son had been incarcerated in Illinois. He visited the son throughout his incarceration, but also made sure to keep in touch with and support the family at the same time. Being there for the family during such a trying period in their lives and providing them with the comfort and clarity that Torah and Yiddishkeit bring led to the family becoming more observant Jews. In fact, Rabbi Scheiman shared that his interview for this article took place while he was on his way to celebrate the chasunah of this woman’s grandson. “This 16-year-old is now in his 50s, marrying off his son who received semichah from a Lubavitcher yeshiva,” he exclaims.

Rabbi Scheiman says that his interactions with this family throughout their ordeal gave him an insight into the trauma the families experience when a loved one is incarcerated. “No one is going for coffee with a friend and saying, ‘Did you hear about my brother? He’s in prison.’ So, on top of their concern for their loved one, the family members are also ashamed and lonely.” Since nowadays many facilities do not permit the chaplain to reach out to a prisoner’s family, Rabbi Scheiman suggests that shluchim who visit incarcerated Jews ask a neighboring shliach to be in touch with the family.

Rabbi Scheiman elects to keep in touch with prisoners once they have served their sentence and left prison. He quotes a Department of Justice study that showed that the recidivism rate for ex-convicts who joined a faith community were lower than that of those who didn’t. In fact, the re-arrest rate for those who received personal mentoring was brought down from

48 percent to 9.8 percent. With this in mind, Rabbi Scheiman blocks out three hours every Friday and calls sixty to seventy of his past contacts. He also invites them to join him for Shabbos meals. “You have to use your common sense about who is a safety risk, but we also trust as shluchim that we will be protected.” Very few of these people take him up on his invitation, Rabbi Scheiman adds, as they often want to disassociate from everything related to their incarceration, including their visitors.

Rabbi Scheiman believes that as shluchim our work with those in prison is something we should share with others. He has brought baalei batim along for visits and feels that this is beneficial for all. “Seeing their Chabad rabbi visiting and according respect to a person who society has deemed worthless, and seeing the person’s face light up at the sight of someone who cares enough to visit him, has a powerful impact.”

Rabbi Chesky Tenenbaum and his wife

history. His work involved delivering an invocation or benediction at its monthly meetings and being on call to provide spiritual and emotional support to the firefighters as needed.

One erev Shabbos, while visiting Jews at the local hospital, Rabbi Tenenbaum met Mr. Martin Hershkowitz, a retired military veteran. As they schmoozed, Rabbi Tenenbaum mentioned that his uncle Rabbi Yankel Goldstein was a chaplain in the military. A month later, Mr. Hershkowitz called and asked Rabbi Tenenbaum if he would like to add the Maryland Defense Force to his chaplaincy repertoire.

“What about my beard?” Rabbi Tenenbaum had asked.

After nine months of Mr. Hershkowitz’s intense efforts to clear through red tape Rabbi Tenenbaum was granted a special exemption to serve in the Maryland Defense Force, thus becoming the first member of any State Guard in America ever permitted to sport facial hair. (Shortly after he received this exemption, a number of fellow shluchim similarly joined the State Defense Force. With Hashem’s help, in 2011, following all the efforts that had been invested on behalf of these shluchim, the military’s beard ban was lifted.)

Rabbi Tenenbaum’s work as military chaplain required arranging holiday services for the Jewish soldiers and attending monthly drills, during which he offered emotional and spiritual support as needed.

A COMMUNITY TO CALL THEIR OWN

Having built relationships with many Jewish law enforcement and military officers in his region, Rabbi Tenenbaum noticed a significant need for religious support specifically for men and women in uniform—law enforcement officials,

LAW ENFORCEMENT CHAPLAINCY

Facing the Door



Chani set out on shlichus to Montgomery County, Maryland in 5765 not all that differently than the rest of their

friends; they worked on community programming alongside fellow shluchim Rabbi and Mrs. Sholom Raichik. After becoming friendly with a Jewish deputy fire chief who frequented the Chabad House, Rabbi Tenenbaum became a chaplain at the local fire department—the first Jewish chaplain in its 84-year

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7. Rabbi Tenenbaum officiates at the funeral of a Jewish firefighter
8. With officers at the annual Kaddish service for Jewish law enforcement members during Police Week in Washington, DC
9. At the bar mitzvah of Chaplain Asher (see below)

PROVIDING THE ANSWER

The Maryland military hosts an annual three-day training session for its chaplains. Attended by chaplains from across the spectrum, as well as many high-ranking members of the military, Rabbi Tenenbaum has found it to be a great opportunity to make connections with them and has made it his business to attend whenever possible.

At a training session a number of years ago, he met a new Methodist chaplain by the name of Asher. Intrigued by his name, Rabbi Tenenbaum asked him about his origins. Asher shared that he had been born in the Ukraine and though both of his parents were Jewish, the family had not practiced their Judaism due to the inherent danger. The family had eventually emigrated to the United States, where Asher had undergone a conversion RL and become a minister.

Asher accepted Rabbi Tenenbaum's offer to put on tefillin and a bar mitzvah was duly scheduled for the next morning. Rabbi Tenenbaum explained to the crowd that Chaplain Asher is Jewish and that he would be marking his bar mitzvah by donning tefillin. Tears welled up in Asher's eyes as he recited Shema. Rabbi Tenenbaum sang a heartfelt siman tov umazal tov and shared cake and grape juice with all those assembled.

A number of months after the bar mitzvah, Asher emailed Rabbi Tenenbaum

a link to his blog, requesting that he take a look at it. He had posted a photo of Nazis rounding up Jews in Ukraine in the early 1940s and captioned it with the following statement: "Any of these people could have been my grandmother or aunt who were murdered by the Nazis." Beneath the caption was a photo of Asher putting on tefillin, followed by his caption: "This is my answer to them."

Regardless of whatever layers may be concealing it, a pintele Yid can never be extinguished. And we never know when we will be granted the opportunity to bring it to the surface. In Rabbi Tenenbaum's case, it was through his work as chaplain for the uniformed personnel in his community.

public safety officers, local members of the military, and veterans. So, in 5771 the Tenenbaums moved to nearby Baltimore and opened the first Chabad House catering specifically to Jewish men and women in uniform. With a full range of Chabad House peulos, the servicemen and women come to connect with their Yiddishkeit and with others who share similar experiences. The Tenenbaums provide one-on-one counseling to those who suffer from post-traumatic stress disorder and offer emotional support to those who may need it due to the high-stress nature of their work.



Rabbi Tenenbaum emphasizes that providing for the religious needs of men and women in uniform can be

done by any shliach anywhere, without infringing on a pre-existing shlichus. “Until we opened the Chabad House catering specifically to uniformed personnel, my work as chaplain for the fire department and State Defense Force took up a total of about 10 percent of my time,” Rabbi Tenenbaum says. “Though I was obligated to make myself available to people of all faiths, the fact that I was working alongside non-Jewish chaplains meant that approximately 70 percent of my interactions were with Jews—despite the fact that they only made up about 10 percent of the service population.”

“It starts out with simple small steps,” he says. “Visit your local police and fire stations and get to know the chiefs, whether Jewish or not. Introduce yourself as a rabbi and offer your services. Build a relationship with them so that they associate you as the go-to person for anything Jewish. You may even find that the non-Jewish officers will lead you to their Jewish friends and co-workers.”

Becoming an official chaplain for law enforcement agencies requires presenting proof of semicha and transcripts from your post-secondary yeshiva, and committing your services for a minimal amount of time (usually about once a month but this varies from one agency to the next; be sure to verify specifics with the administrator before making any commitment). You may be called upon to deliver an invocation or benediction at graduation or award ceremonies (dozens of such speeches are available on shluchimexchange.com), and will be asked to be on call during a situation of crisis RL.

Like all other chaplains, you will be expected to serve people of all faiths, so long as it does not negate your religious standards. Rabbi Tenenbaum is sometimes called upon to deliver an invocation or benediction at meetings or ceremonies. “I usually read a portion of Tehillim with the officers and then recite a prayer for the safety of themselves and their families,” he says, advising that the invocation or benediction should not exceed two minutes.

Fulfilling his role as chaplain—including his newest role as chaplain to the United States Secret Service—has granted Rabbi Tenenbaum with many opportunities to create personal relationships with a broad assortment of high ranking officers. Their respect for Rabbi Tenenbaum has in turn led them to assist numerous shluchim in matters varying from street closures for car menorah parades to Chabad House fire safety issues. In the wake of the horrific Pittsburgh massacre, many law enforcement officers reached out to Rabbi Tenenbaum and asked how they could be of assistance to the national Jewish community.

Reflecting on his chaplaincy experiences, Rabbi Tenenbaum shares that the greatest esteem is earned by holding true to matters of principle. “When I know that I will be meeting with a high-ranking female official, I try to call in advance to explain that I will not be



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10. Affixing a mezuzah on the doorpost of an officer's home

11. Speaking at the annual Kaddish service for Jewish law enforcement members during Police Week in Washington, DC

12. With uncle Rabbi Yankel Goldstein

shaking hands with her due to our religion's laws of modesty,” he shares. While he has encountered some awkward situations, on the whole they have brought about a kiddush Hashem and respect from those involved.

Rabbi Tenenbaum sometimes has difficulty finding the Jews among this group, many of whom don't want to break rank and appear different. “My meetings with uniformed officials gives me a constant reminder of what my attitude should be,” he says. “No matter where we may be, the officers always sit facing the door. They're always on the lookout for who or what might potentially be passing by or coming in. Our job as shluchim is to be constantly looking out for that Yiddishe neshama who might cross our path—or perhaps just briefly surface upon the horizon—and be there for him in whatever way he may need.”

Rabbi Tenenbaum is available to share his story, “The Rabbi in Uniform,” with your community. Contact him at rabbict@jewishusamd.org for more information.



WHAT ALEPH INSTITUTE CAN DO FOR YOU

At the Rebbe's behest, Aleph Institute was established by Rabbi Sholom Ber Lipskar in 5741, addressing the needs of thousands of Jews in institutional environments across the United States, such as prisons, mental health facilities, and rehabilitation centers. Aleph Institute also provides spiritual support for thousands of military personnel in the United States Armed Forces in their stations across the globe.

For a shliach who is interested in pursuing chaplaincy, Aleph is the premier source of information and support. "We have contacts in more than 600 correctional facilities in the USA and service over 2,000 military personnel around the globe," says Rabbi Aaron Lipskar, executive director of the Aleph Institute. "We believe shluchim are the ideal points of contact for these people and will do what we can to help a shliach initiate or further his chaplaincy activities."

Has your interest in shlichus as a chaplain been piqued? Are you a shliach who wants to incorporate prison visitation or military chaplaincy into your pre-existing shlichus? Do you have community members who can volunteer to bring joy and Yiddishkeit to Jews in your local correctional facilities?

CONTACT RABBI MENDY KATZ FROM ALEPH AT mmk@aleph-institute.org FOR THE FOLLOWING SHLICHUS AIDS:

-  A list of local prisons and history of Jewish activity
-  Help to cover volunteers' expenses
-  References for military or prison chaplaincy
-  Information about local facilities that are looking to fill contracts
-  Support to understand the chaplain's role and how to best execute it
-  Insight into navigating the bureaucratic processes involved

Aleph is recognized and endorsed by the US Department of Defense and works tirelessly on behalf of prisoners and their families. They are also advocates for alternative sentencing and support of youth at risk.

"The Rebbe entrusted his shluchim with the mission of reaching every Jew, no matter in what kind of state he is found," says Rabbi Lipskar. "For a lonely Jew in prison or on an army base, a shliach may be the closest source of Yiddishkeit in a wide radius. We are looking for shluchim to help us make sure we fulfill our mandate to its fullest potential." 